

name, is not always comic, nor particularly light; also includes spoken dialogue.

opera seria

Literally “serious **opera**,” the direct opposite of opera buffa; characterized by heroic or mythological plots, and formality in both music and action.

**operetta**

Italian for “little **opera**,” sometimes known as “light opera”; a lighter 19th-century style including spoken dialogue.

**oratorio**

A sacred work for vocal soloists and choir with instrumental accompaniment; differs from an **opera** in that an oratorio is a concert piece, not a drama.

**overture**

From the French for “opening”; an instrumental introduction to an **opera** or ballet, in which some of the main musical themes are presented.

**pitch**

The position of one sound in relation to the range of **tonal** sounds—how high or low it is—which depends on the frequency of sound waves.